

048. Chapter 4 Verses 14-17

Lectures by Swami Sarvapriyananda

VERSE 4.14

न मां कर्माणि लिम्पन्ति न मे कर्मफले स्पृहा ।
इति मां योऽभिजानाति कर्मभिर्न स बध्यते ॥ 14 ॥

na māṃ karmāṇi limpanti
na me karmaphale sprhā |
iti māṃ yo'bhijānāti
karmabhirna sa badhyate ||

- ◆ **na** – not; **mām** – Me; **karmāṇi** – actions; **limpanti** – taint/stain;
- ◆ **na** – not; **me** – for Me; **karma-phale** – in the fruit of action; **sprhā** – desire;
- ◆ **iti** – thus; **mām** – Me; **yaḥ** – who; **abhijānāti** – knows;
- ◆ **karmabhiḥ** – by actions; **na** – not; **saḥ** – he; **badhyate** – is bound.

Actions do not taint Me, nor have I desire for the fruit of actions; He who knows Me thus is not bound by karma.

VERSE 4.15

एवं ज्ञात्वा कृतं कर्म पूर्वैरपि मुमुक्षुभिः ।
कुरु कर्मैव तस्मात्त्वं पूर्वैः पूर्वतरं कृतम् ॥ 15 ॥

evam jñātvā kṛtaṁ karma
pūrvairapi mumukṣubhiḥ |
kuru karmaiva tasmāttvaṁ
pūrvaiḥ pūrvataraṁ kṛtaṁ ||

- ◆ **evam** – thus; **jñātvā** – knowing; **kṛtaṁ** – was performed; **karma** – action;
- ◆ **pūrvaiḥ** – by the ancients; **api** – also; **mumukṣubhiḥ** – seekers of liberation;
- ◆ **kuru** – perform; **karma** – action; **eva** – only; **tasmāt** – therefore; **tvam** – you;
- ◆ **pūrvaiḥ** – by the ancients; **pūrvataram** – in olden times; **kṛtaṁ** – performed.

Thus knowing, the ancient spiritual aspirants performed the action. Therefore you shall do the same (desireless) action as performed by the ancients in older times.

VERSE 4.16

किं कर्म किमकर्मेति कवयोऽप्यत्र मोहिताः ।
तत्ते कर्म प्रवक्ष्यामि यज्ज्ञात्वा मोक्षयसेऽशुभात् ॥ 16 ॥

kiṃ karma kimakarmeti
kavayo'pyatra mohitāḥ |
tatte karma pravakṣyāmi
yajjñātvā mokṣayase'subhāt ||

- ◆ **kim** – what; **karma** – action; **kim** – what; **akarma** – inaction; **iti** – thus;
- ◆ **kavayaḥ** – the wise/poets; **api** – even; **atra** – in this; **mohitāḥ** – are deluded;
- ◆ **tat** – that; **te** – to you; **karma** – action; **pravakṣyāmi** – I shall explain;
- ◆ **yat** – which; **jñātvā** – knowing; **mokṣayase** – you will be liberated; **a'subhāt** – from evil/bondage.

What is action, and what is not action? In this matter, even the wise are deluded. I will teach you that action knowing which you shall be liberated from evil.

VERSE 4.17

कर्मणो ह्यपि बोद्धव्यं बोद्धव्यं च विकर्मणः ।
अकर्मणश्च बोद्धव्यं गहना कर्मणो गतिः ॥ 17 ॥

karmaṇo hyapi boddhavyaṁ
boddhavyaṁ ca vikarmaṇaḥ |
akarmaṇaśca boddhavyaṁ
gahanā karmaṇo gatiḥ ||

- ◆ **karmaṇaḥ** – of action; **hi** – indeed; **api** – also; **boddhavyam** – should be known;
- ◆ **boddhavyam** – should be known; **ca** – and; **vikarmaṇaḥ** – of forbidden action;
- ◆ **akarmaṇaḥ** – of inaction; **ca** – and; **boddhavyam** – should be known;
- ◆ **gahanā** – profound/mysterious; **karmaṇaḥ** – of action; **gatiḥ** – the path/way.

The nature of action (enjoined by the Sastras) and of wrong action (prohibited by the Sastras) and also of inaction should be known, because deep and difficult to understand is the path of action.